

IR III: Constructivism / Other Approaches (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: PG = Goldstein & Pevehouse, *International Relations* — ch. 3, §3.3–3.6 (*Social Theories* [constructivism + postmodernism] · *Marxism* · *Peace Studies* · *Gender Theories*). · Lecturer: Ayça Uygur Wessel. Deck: "Social constructivism & critical IR."

Theme of the lecture (deck). After realism (power) and liberalism (cooperation), a third family shifts the question from **material facts to social meaning**. The deck's two questions: **(A) social constructivism** — *how do ideas, identities, norms and interaction construct interests and behaviour?* and **(B) critical IR theory** — *how do power and hierarchy shape those ideas and the international order itself?*

★ **The heart of the lecture:** for realism and (most) liberalism, states arrive with **interests already formed** and just pursue them. Constructivism denies this: **interests are not given — they are socially constructed** through **identities, norms and interaction** (social context → identity → interests → behaviour). Its slogan: "**anarchy is what states make of it**" (Wendt). **Critical theories** then add the question of **power**: they ask how a particular order comes to look "**natural**" — and **who benefits and who is silenced** (Marxism, Gramsci, world-systems, postcolonialism, feminist/queer IR).

The red thread. *Where do interests and "the way things are" come from?* Realism/liberalism take them as given; **constructivism** says they're **made through meaning**; **critical theory** says that meaning is **made through power and hierarchy**. For any event ask: *what identities and norms make this action thinkable — and whose interests does the "normal" order serve?*

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Constructivism** — interests/identities are **socially constructed**, not given; draws on the **identity principle**.
- **Social facts vs material facts** — a tank/border/nuke is *material*; its **meaning** (threatening? legitimate?) is a **social fact**.
- **"Anarchy is what states make of it"** (Wendt 1992) — anarchy doesn't dictate friend-or-enemy.
- **Norms + logic of appropriateness** (vs realism's **logic of consequences**); **norm entrepreneurs**, NGOs, IOs.
- **Postmodernism** — texts/discourse, **deconstruction**, **subtext**; states as "fictions."
- **Critical theory** — denaturalise the order; **hierarchy** not just anarchy; **power over ideas/knowledge**.
- **Marxism** — class struggle; **Marx (domestic) vs Lenin (imperialism)**; **Gramsci** (hegemony = consent); **Wallerstein** (core/periphery); **postcolonialism / Said** (Orientalism).
- **Feminist & queer IR** — difference · liberal · postmodern feminism; the **masculinity of realism**.
- **Peace studies** — conflict resolution/**mediation**, **positive peace**, **structural violence**, **nonviolence**, **militarism**.

A. Social constructivism (PG §3.3 + deck)

| The puzzle — why does the same world produce different "realities"? (deck)

Core: the system contains **material facts** (armies, territory, no world government) — but **material facts don't tell us what they mean**. Meaning is **socially constructed**.

- **The deck's puzzle:** why does the US treat **British** nuclear weapons utterly differently from **North Korean** ones? By raw military power **Britain is far stronger** than North Korea — yet no one calls British nukes a threat. Realism (capabilities) can't explain it; **shared history, alliance and identity** can. → *The identity of the other, not just its capabilities, decides whether it's a threat.*
- **A second puzzle:** why do practices once seen as **normal** (colonialism, racial hierarchy, conquest, piracy) later become **illegitimate**? Because the **norms** that give them meaning change.

| ★ What constructivism is — interests are socially constructed

Core: **constructivism** asks *how states come to understand what their interests are*. Where realism/liberalism take interests as **given**, constructivism says interests are **constituted** by **social context + interaction** → **identities** → **interests** → **behaviour**. It's best called an **approach** (not a theory) built on the **identity principle**.

- **Material facts ≠ political meaning (deck):** a **tank**, a **border**, a **nuclear weapon** are material; **money**, **sovereignty**, **borders**, **diplomatic status**, **alliances**, **rights** are **social facts** — they exist only because actors **collectively recognise and act on them**. The question is never just "is there a tank?" but "*is the tank threatening? is the border legitimate?*"
- **Identity → interests (deck):** an **identity** is an actor's social understanding of **who it is in relation to others** (friend / ally / rival / enemy / neutral / "**rogue state**"). **Interests change when identities and relationships change**, and identities are **(re)shaped through interaction**. (*Chain: Who am I? → Who are you? → Are you one of us/them? → What kind of relationship? → What should I want/fear/do?*)
- **Logic of appropriateness vs logic of consequences:** realists/neoliberals assume a **logic of consequences** ("what will happen to me if I act this way?"); constructivists add a **logic of appropriateness** ("how *should* I behave, given who I am?"). *Example (PG):* the US intervened in **Somalia (1992)** — of minimal strategic value — because **norms about who deserves protection** had widened (from "Christians" in the 19th c. to a universal human-rights frame).
- **Identities change over time (PG):** **Europe** went from the continent of two world wars to a place where war became "**unthinkable**" (identities now tied to the EU); **pirates** went from the scourge of the seas to theme-park **mascots**; **Switzerland/Canada** value a *social status* (neutrality, peacekeeping), not just material power. (*What counts as "threatening" is neither universal nor timeless.*)

| ★ "Anarchy is what states make of it" (Wendt 1992)

Core: the signature constructivist claim — **anarchy has no fixed logic**. It doesn't *tell* a state whether another is friend or enemy; that meaning is built through **interaction and shared understandings**.

	Realist chain	Constructivist chain
Start	anarchy	anarchy
→	self-help	interaction + shared meanings
→	power / insecurity	friendship / rivalry / enmity
→	competition	different interests & behaviour
Question asked	"What will happen if I do this?"	"Is what I do legitimate, given who I am?"

- **Take-away:** for realists anarchy **forces** competition; for constructivists the **same anarchy** can produce a security community (allies who'd never fight) *or* a rivalry — depending on the meanings states build. *(This is the direct answer to realism's structural claim.)*

Norms — and how they change (the apartheid case)

Core: a **norm** is a **shared expectation of appropriate behaviour** for an actor with a given identity (e.g. "states should not use certain weapons"; "respect sovereignty"; "governments should not openly defend racial supremacy"). Norms **shape legitimacy, identities, interests and behaviour** — and actors in turn **reproduce, contest and change** them.

- **How norms spread (PG):** **norm entrepreneurs** (individuals who travel, write, lobby elites); **social movements & NGOs** (e.g. the anti-apartheid movement building a global norm of racial equality); **IOs** (UN, NATO) diffusing standards of appropriate conduct.
- ★ **South African apartheid (deck's worked case).** Racial hierarchy was once embedded in domestic *and* international order → **norm entrepreneurs/movements** challenged it → a **global norm of racial equality** strengthened → racially discriminatory rule became **hard to justify** → NGOs + IOs + states mobilised **boycotts, sanctions, diplomatic isolation**. **Constructivist claim:** *changing ideas about legitimate rule changed the political environment in which states calculated their interests* — power politics alone can't explain the fall of apartheid.
- A "natural experiment" (PG): Britain barely funded the Yugoslavia war-crimes tribunal — realists said "Britain sides with Serbia"; liberals said "free-riding." Then **Blair** replaced **Major (1997)** with *no change* in Britain's strategic interests — yet policy **flipped** (arrests, funding). → the change in **identity/leadership ideas** drove the outcome, supporting constructivism.

Postmodernism (PG §3.3.2)

Core: postmodernism denies a **single objective reality** and studies **texts and discourse** — how we *talk and write* about IR. It **deconstructs** realism's key move (the **unitary state actor**) and hunts for the **subtext** (hidden meanings, omissions).

- **States as "fictions":** postmodernists say states have no tangible reality — they're **stories** we tell to organise the actions of millions. Realists were **amazed** when the "unitary" **Soviet Union split into 15 pieces** — the label had masked divergent internal experiences.
- **Deconstruction & subtext:** to *deconstruct* a text is to tease apart its words to reveal what's **omitted or implicit**. Realism's subtext **omits** women/gender, classes, poor countries, non-military power — a

"narrow, one-sided story" that (postmodernists say) serves **powerful actors**. (*Postmodernism set the stage for, and was largely absorbed into, constructivism.*)

★ **Exercise (deck)** — build a **constructivist explanation of Putin's war on Ukraine**. *Don't ask whether Putin's claims are **true**; ask how Russia's leadership **constructs the meaning** of the situation, using the chain **IDENTITY → THREAT PERCEPTION → LEGITIMACY → BEHAVIOUR**. Who is "Russia" in the narrative? Who are Ukraine / NATO / "the West"? What is presented as the threat? Which norms are invoked to make force look legitimate? How does this construction make invasion representable as **defence/protection** rather than aggression? → the point: identities and norms make some actions **thinkable and legitimate** and others not.*

- **Critics (PG)**: realists say norms are just **covers for interests**; liberals say constructivists neglect **formal institutions**; both note it's hard to tell a **genuine** identity from one **adopted strategically** for material gain (aid, trade, membership).

B. Critical IR theory — adding power & hierarchy (*deck + PG §3.4*)

Core (deck): constructivism asks *how* realities are constructed; **critical approaches** add the question of **power** — *how are particular realities made to appear **natural**, and **who** **benefits**?* Critical theory refuses to take existing institutions, categories and power relations **for granted**: it aims to **expose domination** → **denaturalise the order** → **open possibilities for change**.

- **The major shifts (deck)**: anarchy → also examine **hierarchy** · state interests → ask **how interests are produced** · power-as-capabilities → also **power over ideas & knowledge** · "who acts?" → **who is marginalised/silenced?** · "how does order work?" → "**whose order is it?**"

| **Marxism & global capitalism (PG §3.4)**

Core: Marxist approaches see **both** IR and domestic politics as arising from **unequal relations between economic classes** — shifting the unit of analysis from **state ↔ state** to **class, capital, labour, production, the global economy**. Key question (deck): **who produces value, and who captures it?**

- **Class struggle**: more powerful classes **exploit** the less powerful by denying them their fair share of the **surplus** they create; ultimately this scales up to **richer vs poorer world regions** (North–South).
- ★ **Marx vs Lenin (the exam distinction — LO 3.4)**:
 - **Marx = a domestic theory of class struggle**. In industrialising Europe, labour creates the surplus; workers (the **proletariat**) should recapture it through struggle. Marx expected revolution in the **advanced** capitalist countries.
 - **Lenin = a theory of imperialism (the international extension)**. European capitalists invest in **colonies** for big profits, then use part of those profits to "**buy off**" the **working class at home** (so no revolution there). Once the world was carved up, imperial expansion could only come at rivals' expense → **inter-imperialist war (WWI)**. So revolution comes in the **poor/"backward"** periphery (Russia 1917, China 1949), not the rich core.

- **Peasants (not just proletariat):** contrary to Marx, the great 20th-c. revolutions were **peasant** rebellions (China the largest). **Trotsky** (spread revolution worldwide) lost to **Stalin** ("socialism in one country").

The critical-theory strands the deck adds — Gramsci · Wallerstein · postcolonialism/Said

Core: the deck bundles several **critical** approaches that extend the Marxist insight from *material* class to **ideas, structure and identity**.

- **Gramsci — hegemony as *consent*, not just coercion.** Hegemonic power is bigger than force: it rests on **consent** — dominant ideas and institutions make a particular order look "**normal, legitimate, universal, common sense**" ("this is simply how the world works"). **Critical question:** when the "rules of the game" go unchallenged, ask "**who got to write the rules?**"
- **Wallerstein — world-systems / dependency.** The global economy is a **single hierarchy** of three zones (the deck's diagram):

Zone	Government	Production role	Wages / welfare
Core	democratic	imports raw materials, exports manufactures ; high investment	high wages, welfare services
Semi-periphery	authoritarian	exports raw materials & mature manufactures ; imports advanced manufactures	low wages, little welfare
Periphery	non-democratic	exports raw materials , imports manufactures	low wages, no welfare

→ *dependency theory's claim: the periphery isn't "not yet developed" — it is **kept** poor by its structural position, which channels surplus to the core (cf. **Lenin**).*

- **Postcolonial theory — colonialism created *enduring* hierarchies (deck): material** (wealth, trade, borders, institutions), **knowledge** (whose history/concepts count?), and **social** (civilised/backward · developed/underdeveloped · modern/traditional · "**West / Rest**"). **Core question:** *how does the colonial past keep structuring the international present?*
- **Said — Orientalism & "othering."** Power works by **representation**: the West constructs "the Other" through recurring **binaries** — **Self** (modern, rational, civilised, orderly) vs **Other** (backward, irrational, uncivilised, chaotic). The mechanism: **represent difference → essentialise groups → produce hierarchy → make unequal treatment seem reasonable**. "*Representation constitutes the subjects we then act upon.*"

Feminist & queer IR (PG §3.6 + deck)

Core: gender and sexuality aren't just traits of individuals — they structure the ideas, roles and hierarchies of IR. Feminists ask what becomes **visible** once we stop treating *the state, war, security* as gender-neutral: **whose** security, **whose** labour, **whose** experiences, **whose** voices? All strands agree **gender matters**; they split on **how**.

Strand	Core claim	On women in IR
Difference feminism	Realism reflects a masculine worldview (autonomy, separation, force = "manly"); women, on average, are less warlike / better at connection & peacemaking	Real change needs many women → would transform ("feminise") the system
Liberal feminism	Men and women are equal ; "essential" differences are trivial/nonexistent	Include women in male preserves (leaders, soldiers) — they play the game the same way ; exclusion just wastes talent
Postmodern feminism	Gender is real but arbitrary & flexible (not fixed); deconstruct the subtext of realist language	Reject both: don't glorify "feminine virtue" or just add women to war

- **The masculinity of realism (difference feminism):** realism's **autonomy/sovereignty/anarchy** mirror a "masculine psyche" (separation over connection); the public(masculine)/private(feminine) split maps onto the international(anarchic)/domestic(ordered) split → *realism constructs IR as "a man's world."*
- **Evidence both ways:** the **overlapping bell curves** — genders differ *on average* but overlap hugely (liberal feminists stress the **overlap**: individual women perform like men; difference feminists stress the **shift**: women *as a group* differ, e.g. the ~10-point **gender gap** in support for military action). **Women state leaders** (Thatcher, Gandhi, Meir, Merkel...) were **not** more peaceful — supporting liberal feminism. **Postmodern feminists** deconstruct the sexual **subtext** of weapons talk ("It's a boy" for the H-bomb; "power/potency").

Peace studies (PG §3.5)

Core: peace studies shifts IR from the **systemic** level to **individual/domestic/transnational** social relations, and openly **rejects "objectivity"** (knowledge through **action/participation**). It reconceives both peace and war.

- **Conflict resolution — the mediation toolkit (LO 3.5):** **mediation** = a **third party** helps two sides settle short of violence (the **UN** is the biggest mediator). Forms: **good offices** (a neutral channel — e.g. Pakistan passing messages between the US & China, 1971); **arbitration** (both sides agree in advance to accept a third party's binding decision — e.g. the city of **Brčko** in the Dayton process); **confidence-building measures** (gradually build trust); **linkage** (bundle issues so a concession on one trades for another — Yalta 1945).
- **Positive vs negative peace:** realism recognises only **negative peace** (the temporary **absence of war**); **positive peace** removes the **underlying causes** — including **structural violence** (poverty, hunger, oppression *built into* social structures, which kill more than direct violence).
- **Militarism** = the **glorification** of war (through films, toys, sport, speeches) and the **structuring of society around war** (the military-industrial complex). Less-militarised cultures (Costa Rica — **no army for 70 years**; post-war Japan) show realism's stress on force isn't **universal**.
- **Nonviolence:** a unilateral refusal of violent leverage — **Gandhi** (Indian independence), **MLK** (US civil rights), and **Gene Sharp**'s strategies (taught to **Arab Spring** activists). Practical as well as moral — often the **cost-effective** tool of the powerless.

★ The four theories compared — "theory changes what we see" (deck capstone)

Core: each theory is a different **pair of glasses** — it makes different things visible and asks a different core question.

Theory	Core question	Interests are...	Key concepts
Realism	Where is the power ?	given (survival, power)	anarchy, self-help, balance of power, security dilemma
Liberalism	What enables cooperation / shapes preferences?	given (peace, prosperity)	institutions, reciprocity, interdependence, democratic peace
Constructivism	How did actors come to understand their interests this way?	socially constructed	identity, norms, social facts, "anarchy is what states make of it"
Critical theory	How did this order become normal — who benefits, who is marginalised?	produced by power/hierarchy	hegemony, class, core/periphery, colonial & gendered hierarchies

*The move across the row: realism & liberalism take the world's **actors and interests as given** and ask how they behave; **constructivism** asks where those interests **come from** (meaning); **critical theory** asks whose **power** made that meaning look natural. (This is the deck's — and the exam's — payoff: pick an event and show what each lens sees and misses.)*

Cases & examples

- **British vs North Korean nukes.** The US fears NK's bomb, not Britain's far larger arsenal → **identity/alliance**, not capabilities, defines the threat. → *Illustrates: **constructivism** vs **realism** — the meaning of a material fact.*
- **South African apartheid.** Norm change (racial equality) → delegitimation → sanctions. → *Illustrates: **norms & norm entrepreneurs** reshaping states' interests.*
- **Blair's Bosnia U-turn (1997).** Same interests, new leadership/identity → opposite policy. → *Illustrates: a "natural experiment" favouring **constructivism** over **realism/liberalism**.*
- **US in Somalia (1992).** Intervention with no strategic payoff → the **logic of appropriateness** + widened norms of who deserves protection. → *Illustrates: **norms over cost-benefit**.*
- **Lysistrata / women's peace movements.** From Aristophanes to WILPF to UNSC Res. 1325 — the long "women as peacemakers" thread (and its limits: female leaders weren't more peaceful). → *Illustrates: the **difference-vs-liberal-feminist** debate.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Constructivism	Interests/identities are socially constructed through norms & interaction (identity principle)
Social fact vs material fact	Meaning collectively recognised (sovereignty, alliance) vs brute matter (a tank)
"Anarchy is what states make of it"	Wendt — anarchy has no fixed logic; friend/enemy is constructed
Norm / norm entrepreneur	Shared expectation of appropriate behaviour; actor who spreads it
Logic of appropriateness vs consequences	"How <i>should</i> I act?" vs "what will happen to me?"
Postmodernism / subtext	Denies single reality; studies discourse; hidden meanings/omissions
Marxism (Marx vs Lenin)	Domestic class struggle vs imperialism (buying off the core's workers)
Hegemony (Gramsci)	Rule by consent — dominant ideas made to seem common sense
World-systems (Wallerstein)	Core / semi-periphery / periphery hierarchy
Orientalism (Said)	Power through representation — Self/Other binaries → hierarchy
Difference / liberal / postmodern feminism	Women differ & would transform IR / women are equal, just include them / gender is real but arbitrary
Positive peace / structural violence	Removing the causes of war / violence built into social structures
Mediation / arbitration	Third party assists a settlement / third party's binding decision

Exam pointers

- Explain what constructivism adds to realism/liberalism: **interests are constructed** (social context → identity → interests → behaviour), with the UK-vs-NK-nukes puzzle.
- State and use "anarchy is what states make of it" — contrast the realist and constructivist chains.
- Show how norms change via norm entrepreneurs/NGOs/IOs — the apartheid case, and the **logic of appropriateness** (Somalia).
- **Distinguish Marx from Lenin** (domestic class struggle vs imperialism) — the LO 3.4 distinction.
- Lay out the critical shift (anarchy→hierarchy, "whose order?") and one strand in depth — Gramsci, Wallerstein's core/periphery, or Said's Orientalism.
- Compare the three feminisms and the **masculinity-of-realism** critique.
- Describe the mediation toolkit (good offices, arbitration, confidence-building, linkage) and **positive vs negative peace** (LO 3.5).
- **Run all four lenses** on one event using the comparison table.

Bridge. IR III completes the theory arc: **realism** (power) → **liberalism** (cooperation) → **constructivism** (meaning) → **critical theory** (power *behind* meaning). Realism and liberalism debate *how given actors behave*; constructivism and critical theory ask *where the actors, interests and "normal" order came from* — and who they serve.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (IR III: Constructivism & Critical Theory)

Sticky bits from constructivism & critical IR.

- "Anarchy is what states make of it" — Alexander **Wendt's** 1992 line is the single most-quoted sentence in constructivism: the *same* anarchy can produce NATO or a knife-fight.
- **Britain's nukes don't scare Washington, North Korea's do** — even though Britain's arsenal is far bigger. Proof that in IR, **identity beats capability**.
- **Pirates went from the terrorists of their day to theme-park mascots** — the textbook's vivid reminder that "what counts as a threat" is **not timeless**. (Imagine your great-grandkids on a *terrorist-themed* ride.)
- **A natural experiment:** Tony **Blair** replacing John Major flipped Britain's Bosnia policy with **no change in national interest** — a rare "clean test" that favoured constructivism.
- **Marx vs Lenin in one line:** Marx expected revolution in the **rich** countries; **Lenin** explained why it came in the **poor** ones — the rich bought off their workers with **colonial** profits.
- **Gramsci's hegemony** = getting people to say "*this is just how the world works*" — power that never has to draw its sword.
- **Wallerstein's world-system:** you're not "**not yet** developed" — the periphery is **kept** peripheral so surplus flows to the **core**.
- **Said's Orientalism:** the West "knows" the East by inventing it — **representation** becomes a tool of domination.
- **Lysistrata (411 BC)** — Aristophanes had the women withhold sex to end the Peloponnesian War; it was read aloud in **1,000 venues in 56 countries** in 2003 to protest the Iraq War.
- **"It's a boy":** the coded cable confirming the first **H-bomb** worked — postmodern feminists' favourite example of the **gendered subtext** of weapons.
- **Costa Rica has had no army since 1948** — a living rebuttal to realism's claim that military force is universal and necessary.